what he thinks I should bowl. Normally, he's good with this, full of ideas, giving me things to think about. This time, he shrugs. I have never seen him shrug like that in the field. I ask him what's wrong. 'We shouldn't be playing, it's too wet,' he says. 'The only reason we're here is because of you.'

As he says it, I remember the last Ashes series in Australia, the one where we had been destroyed 4-0. I had been given out in the last rites, caught behind, the game won by a distance by Australia, everyone just relieved to finish and go home. I didn't think I'd hit it. 'I've not hit it,' I'm telling everyone. 'It isn't out,' as they roll their eyes and clear up the stumps. In my mind then, I only needed a career-best triple century to win a consolation game for England. You just never know.

In the same spell that Broady has shrugged at me, I get a ball to bounce slightly more sharply than a few of the previous deliveries and find Azhar Ali's outside edge. Joe Root takes the catch and as everyone swamps me, relieved and half-apologetic, all wanting to go home, I take the ball and, tongue in cheek, raise it to each corner of the completely empty ground.

I have to do media interviews as the game is finally called a draw, spending 45 minutes on the outfield being interviewed by journalists at a long distance, all of them asking whether this means retirement is any closer. I say no to each of them, that it doesn't mean anything and that I will keep playing for as long as my body lets me. They all nod back, half-believing yet slightly bemused. I get back to the dressing room and discover that every single person has left. It's like there's a theme developing here, me being left alone in these empty dressing rooms. We'll have to celebrate another time then, I think to myself, and pack up to get home to see the girls.